M. Cecilia Ramírez-Michelena

Applied Economist | Research & Policy Project Management
Barcelona, open to relocation | EU and Mercosur work authorization
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Professional Summary

Applied economist and final-stage Ph.D. candidate in Economics with experience developing and managing applied research projects across Spain, the United States, and Uruguay. My work combines applied microeconomic research with randomized evaluations, large administrative and survey datasets, field implementation, staff supervision, budget management, and sustained collaboration with public institutions. I have experience taking research projects from design through implementation, working with multidisciplinary teams and institutional partners, and communicating findings to both academic and policy audiences. Research interests include education, labor markets, gender inequality, and social policy.

Core Competencies: Research project management; applied economic research; randomized evaluations and causal inference; research design and implementation; staff supervision and field-team management; public-sector stakeholder engagement; administrative and survey microdata; budget and grant management; research and policy writing.

Professional Experience

Institut d'Economia de Barcelona, Universitat de Barcelona 01/2023 – Present
Predoctoral Researcher *Barcelona, Spain*

- Conduct doctoral research in education and labor economics on gender inequality, educational choices, and labor-market trajectories. My dissertation combines administrative microdata, survey data, randomized field experiments, and quasi-experimental methods to study educational gains from school electrification in rural Uruguay, the role of students' abilities in shaping gender gaps in STEM choices, and how couples divide paid work when a child arrives.
- Building on findings from my research on gender gaps in STEM, conceived and proposed a school-based randomized information intervention in Catalonia targeting how students interpret their relative academic strengths, which I am now developing with my co-authors for implementation in December 2026. The intervention has particular potential to affect high-achieving female students at the margin of choosing STEM and was designed to be low-cost and scalable. I lead intervention, including treatment and survey design, school engagement, ethics and data protection approvals, preregistration, implementation planning, and budget management.

Education Policy Analytics Lab, College of Education, University of Washington 09/2018 – 09/2019
Research Associate *Seattle, United States*

- Worked in a research-practice partnership with Seattle Public Schools, the largest K–12 public school district in Washington State, analyzing administrative data on teacher effectiveness, absenteeism, staffing, and retention, particularly in schools serving disadvantaged students.
- Worked with senior district leadership, analysts, school administrators, program managers, and teachers' union representatives to turn operational concerns into empirical questions that could be addressed with available data, incorporate institutional knowledge into the analysis, and communicate findings and their limitations through internal reports, technical notes, and presentations for district decision-makers.

Center for Research in Applied Economics, Universidad de Montevideo 06/2015 – 07/2018
Research Assistant and Field Leader *Montevideo, Uruguay*

- Contributed to the design and led field implementation of two randomized evaluations with highly vulnerable populations: a social-benefit and labor-inclusion intervention with more than 300 informal street workers and a digital-inclusion intervention with more than 120 older adults in public long-term care. Across both projects, worked on intervention and survey design, data-quality monitoring, quantitative analysis, and research outputs; co-author of a working paper from the first evaluation and of a peer-reviewed publication from the second.
- For the informal-worker evaluation, piloted the intervention and recruited and coordinated ten social workers responsible for treatment delivery and surveys. Worked closely with them to improve outreach, identify implementation bottlenecks, and adjust field procedures, while coordinating operational issues and data access with a specialized police unit that already worked with this population and with the social security administration.
- For the older-adult evaluation, piloted the intervention, recruited and trained more than 50 volunteers, matched volunteers to participants, and hired an on-site coordinator to supervise daily activities. Worked regularly with hospital leadership and clinical staff to resolve implementation problems, ensure completion of medical and cognitive assessments, and preserve the randomized design when institutional priorities conflicted with it.

Education

Universitat de Barcelona, Barcelona, Spain
Ph.D. candidate in Economics — Thesis submission expected 10/2026
Dissertation: *Unequal Starts, Unequal Choices, Unequal Returns: Essays on Human Capital and Inequality.*
Supervisors: Profs. Lídia Farré and Andreu Arenas.

Visiting doctoral student, **Teachers College, Columbia University**, New York, US — Fall 2026
Visiting doctoral student, **Paris School of Economics**, Paris, France — June 2026

University of Washington, Seattle, United States
M.Ed. in Educational Foundations, Leadership, and Policy Studies — 2021
Specialization in *Organizational and Policy Studies*
M.A. in Economics — 2021

Universidad de Montevideo, Montevideo, Uruguay
M.A. in Economics — 2020
B.A. in Economics — 2016
B.A. in Management and Business Administration — 2016

Selected Grants & Fellowships

Fellowships	Doctoral Fellowship, Fundación Ramón Areces (2023–2027). Fulbright Scholarship for Graduate Studies, Fulbright Commission (2018–2020).
Research Grants	Women and Science Programme, Paris Dauphine–PSL University – EUR 10,000 (2025).

Technical Skills & Languages

Methods & Data	Advanced causal inference methods; randomized evaluations; discrete choice experiments; survey design. Linked administrative records; survey, experimental, and longitudinal microdata.
Research & Project Management	Project design and implementation; fieldwork planning and protocols; staff recruitment, training, and supervision; implementation monitoring and troubleshooting; budget management; stakeholder and institutional coordination; grant applications.
Research Outputs	Academic papers and conference presentations; technical reports and briefings for policymakers and practitioners; grant proposals.
Software	Stata (advanced); R and Python (working knowledge); Microsoft Office; LaTeX; Git/GitHub.
Languages	Spanish, native; English, fluent; Catalan, intermediate.

Selected Research

- Power to Attend: School Electrification and Student Attendance in Rural Uruguay. With M. Blanco and N. D'Agosti. Working Paper, October 2026. Presented at the European Association of Labour Economists (EALE), 2024.
- Math Comparative Advantage and the Gender Gap in STEM: From Upper-Secondary Tracks to University Degrees. With A. Arenas and L. Farré. Working Paper, October 2026. Presented at the BRIDGE Economics of Education Workshop (KU Leuven) and the SEHO Annual Meeting, 2025.
- Who Gives Way? The Child Penalty within Spanish Couples. Working Paper, October 2026.
- Connecting Informal Workers to the State: A Field Experiment in the Streets of Montevideo. With A. Cid, J.M. Cabrera, and M. Blanco. Working Paper, October 2026.
- Tablets for Deeply Disadvantaged Older Adults: Challenges in Long-term Care Facilities. With A. Cid, R. Sotelo, and M. Leguisamo. *International Journal of Human-Computer Studies* (2020).

Student Supervision & Teaching Experience

Universitat de Barcelona – Instructor and B.A. Thesis Advisor, Department of Economics. Spring 2024, 2025, 2026
IFSA Barcelona – Lecturer. Winter 2026
University of Washington – Instructor, Department of Spanish and Portuguese Studies. Fall 2020 – Spring 2021
Universidad de Montevideo – Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics. Fall 2014 – Spring 2015